Policy Topics Codebook

Note: When conceived and run the codebook was called political themes, but retroactively named policy topics because it more accurately represented what was being coded. Broadly speaking, the idea is the same, in that it asks, "what is the post about?" and then as it relates to a policy topic. (The campaigning material was excluded from a theme but is inherently political, hence the name change to simply policy).

Overview

The **unit of analysis** is one post, i.e. everything the "audience" (me) sees/hears – the image/video, any text on the image, speech and the caption. Logos, party names, hashtags, links and authorisation lines ignored. AI-generated images coded the same way. Outside knowledge used to recognise people, places and slogans, but not to read in a point the post doesn't actually make.

Each post coded 1/0 for each of the eight themes (binary coding scheme).

Basic criteria for counting a theme

- The post makes an actual claim about that policy area, i.e. it could be summed up in a sentence. Passing mentions not counted.
- General metric: if the mention were deleted, would the summary of the post change? If not, not coded. In short posts (e.g. a card, a slogan, a few lines) a mention is usually the point, so coded. Long posts follow R6 & override discretion
- Images weighted more heavily. An image depicting something pertaining directly to key words should always be coded, unless is very clearly metaphorical

No policy, no code

- **Examples:** rally and visit photos, "vote for us", thank-yous, polls and results, holiday greetings, condolences, congratulations, and personal attacks with no policy mentioned.
- **Exceptions:** posts celebrating or remembering the nation (SOV), International Women's Day (CULT), attacks on the EU (SOV), and mourning that names a policy cause, e.g. "killed by drug traffickers" (that theme).

Themes

Theme	Includes	Excluded
IMM Immigration and asylum	borders and boats (incl. army/police at the border), asylum seekers, asylum centres, deportation and returns, migration numbers (legal/illegal), pacts and quotas, integration demands, citizenship rules, “natives first” in housing/benefits, NGOs helping migrants; migration deals with transit states	• EU citizens moving under free movement, unless arrival or numbers are the point
ISL Islam and Islamism	Islam as a religion/presence, e.g. mosques, Muslims praying, veil and burqa, sharia, Ramadan, halal slaughter, Islamist extremism and terror, “Islamisation”	• Muslim-majority states acting as states (DEF) • Islam present but not part of the claim
CRI Crime, security and punishment	crime and insecurity, police, sentencing, prisons, street disorder, riots, vandalism, drugs, gangs, fraud, terrorism, threats or violence against politicians (incl. the party’s own), road-safety enforcement	• “Criminals” or “coup plotters” as insults • Corruption claims against domestic rivals • Safety words without a specific crime referent
SOV Sovereignty, nation and identity	the nation, i.e. pride, national days and remembrance, flag, heritage, traditions (incl. religious ones defended as heritage), language, “Western values”, regional identity and autonomy; national unity against separatism, the EU as an adversary, e.g. Brussels, the Commission, EU rules, budgets, scandals; a federal Europe vs a “Europe of nations”, UN, WHO, WEF or Agenda 2030 as overriding national self-government, race and indigeneity as the subject, e.g. Indigenous recognition and policy, race-based law, multiculturalism as doctrine, racism/antisemitism (Aus centric)	• The EU mentioned only as a venue, in a single clause/hashtag, or neutrally or positively
ECON Economy and public services	cost of living, prices, inflation, energy bills, tax, pensions, benefits, housing costs and supply, business, industry, jobs, wages, red tape, trade and tariffs, public services and infrastructure, e.g. health care, school places and funding, transport, roads, local services, public money spent/wasted; veterans’ welfare	• A cost used only as the argument for another theme • A service that is only the setting for another theme

Theme	Includes	Excluded
LAND Land, agriculture, energy and environment	farmers, agriculture, fishing, rural life, food standards and imports; water, rivers and dams, energy supply and policy (incl. the energy industry), Green Deal, net zero, CO2 taxes, climate law, climate scepticism, climate activists, environmental rules; animal welfare	• Energy bills and prices (ECON)
CULT Gender, family and culture war	gender ideology, trans and LGBT issues, sex education, abortion, birth rates, family norms, parental leave rules, women's rights, safety, freedom or dress (where the post is about women), "woke", cancel culture, political correctness, universities as indoctrination, free speech as a principle	• "Woke" as a passing label • The party complaining that it was censored, banned or insulted
DEF Defence and foreign relations	war and peace, e.g. Ukraine, Gaza, Hamas, armed forces as policy, rearmament, arms deliveries, conscription, sanctions, NATO, national security, relations with foreign states as states (incl. EU members), diplomacy, treaties	• Metaphors (e.g. "trade war", "man of peace") • Contact with or endorsements from foreign allies • A country named only as the origin of migrants/criminals

Decision Rulings

1. **Slogans.** Only coded when it's the main message (slogan card, biggest text, poster filling the frame). Most posts have a slogan somewhere, so counting sign-offs, hashtags, badges and footers would inflate SOV. Same for videos where the speech is just a rallying cry.
2. **Lists.** When a list of issues is the main content (pledge card, programme slide, event topics), each item naming a policy area is coded, as the party is naming its own issues. Word key used unless the post makes the meaning clear. Key terms count in any form ("economic", "sovereign"). Reasons to vote ("for prosperity, for security") only count when they're the only policy content. Announcements, complaints in an attack on a rival, and why supporters back the party aren't reasons to vote.
3. **Media and caption.** Both coded, as the audience sees both. A caption discussing a theme at length counts even if the image is unrelated. A short caption on a long video only counts if it makes its own policy point, usually it's just a teaser.
4. **Images without words.** Coded when what's shown is the subject, e.g. a migrant boat (IMM), street prayer (ISL), a tractor protest (LAND). A known person shown without a claim isn't coded.

5. **Visits.** The sector shown/named is coded, e.g. farmers at a farm show (LAND), police at a station (CRI), as the choice of visit points to the issue. Rallies and walkabouts aren't.
6. **Long posts + Overriding.** Speech past about a minute or a caption past about five sentences. A theme needs at least a few sentences, otherwise long speeches pick up every theme mentioned in passing.
7. **Attacks on rivals.** The policy attacked is coded, e.g. "Habeck's heating law ruins families" is LAND + ECON. Attacks with no policy content (incompetence, lies, scandal) aren't. Attacks on the EU are SOV.
8. **Humour, headlines and quotes.** Jokes and memes coded on their topic. Press cuttings coded on the headline and the party's caption, not the article, as that's what people read. Quote cards coded on what the quote says.
9. **Duplicates.** Same media and text as an earlier post copies its codes as (ignoring translation, hashtags, emoji, spelling etc.). Same media with a new caption is recoded, keeping the media's themes and reading the caption. Different media (new cut or interview, card made into a video, one photo from a set, photo card vs text card) is a new post. Resized, letterboxed or re-encoded files count as the same media.
10. **Any Policy outside the eight.** Not coded. *(Formerly had an "other policy" here, but it had so few posts for the corpus it was dropped)*

Edge Cases

- A theme used only to justify another point belongs to that point, e.g. "the boats cost £30m, so stop the boats" is IMM, not ECON.
- ECON only added as a second theme when the post names jobs, firms, industry, bills, prices or the cost to taxpayers.
- Exceptions are marked as overridden, i.e. when judgement call made at discretion of coder

Word Key

List word	Theme
migration, immigration, borders, asylum, boats	IMM
Islam, Islamism	ISL
security, safety, crime, police, criminal justice	CRI
Europe, Brussels, EU, sovereignty, national identity, homeland, our culture, Flanders	SOV
purchasing power, cost of living, prices, taxes, jobs, wages, pensions, prosperity, economy, health care, NHS, housing, schools, infrastructure	ECON
energy, farmers, agriculture, countryside, rural, climate, environment	LAND (energy prices are ECON)!
gender, woke, free speech, women's rights, family policy, birth rate	CULT
peace, war, defence, army, national security	DEF
freedom, democracy, future, common sense, our people, respect, hope, change, values, family	Not coded

Recurring slogans

Coded only when the slogan is the dominant/only message of the post.

Slogan	Account	Theme
Vlaanderen weer van ons (“Flanders ours again”)	Vlaams Belang, Van Grieken	SOV
Minder migratie, meer koopkracht, meer veiligheid, meer Vlaanderen	Vlaams Belang, Van Grieken	IMM, ECON, CRI, SOV
Più Italia, meno Europa (“More Italy, less Europe”)	Lega, Salvini	SOV
Vol is vol (“Full is full”)	Wilders, PVV	IMM
Stop the boats	Reform UK, Farage	IMM
We want our country back	Reform UK, Farage	SOV
Para que Cataluña vuelva a ser Cataluña; recuperar Cataluña (“take Catalonia back”)	VOX, Abascal	SOV
Dit is uw land! (“This is your country!”); “our Netherlands, which we will reconquer”	Wilders, PVV	SOV
Any other “our country back”, “this is your country” or “reconquer” line	Any	SOV
Zeit für Deutschland (“Time for Germany”)	AfD, Weidel	Not coded in itself; code the card’s topic
#DeshalbAfD, #sóloquedavox, #VivementLe9Juin, #LEuropeSansEux and other standing hashtags	Various	Not coded